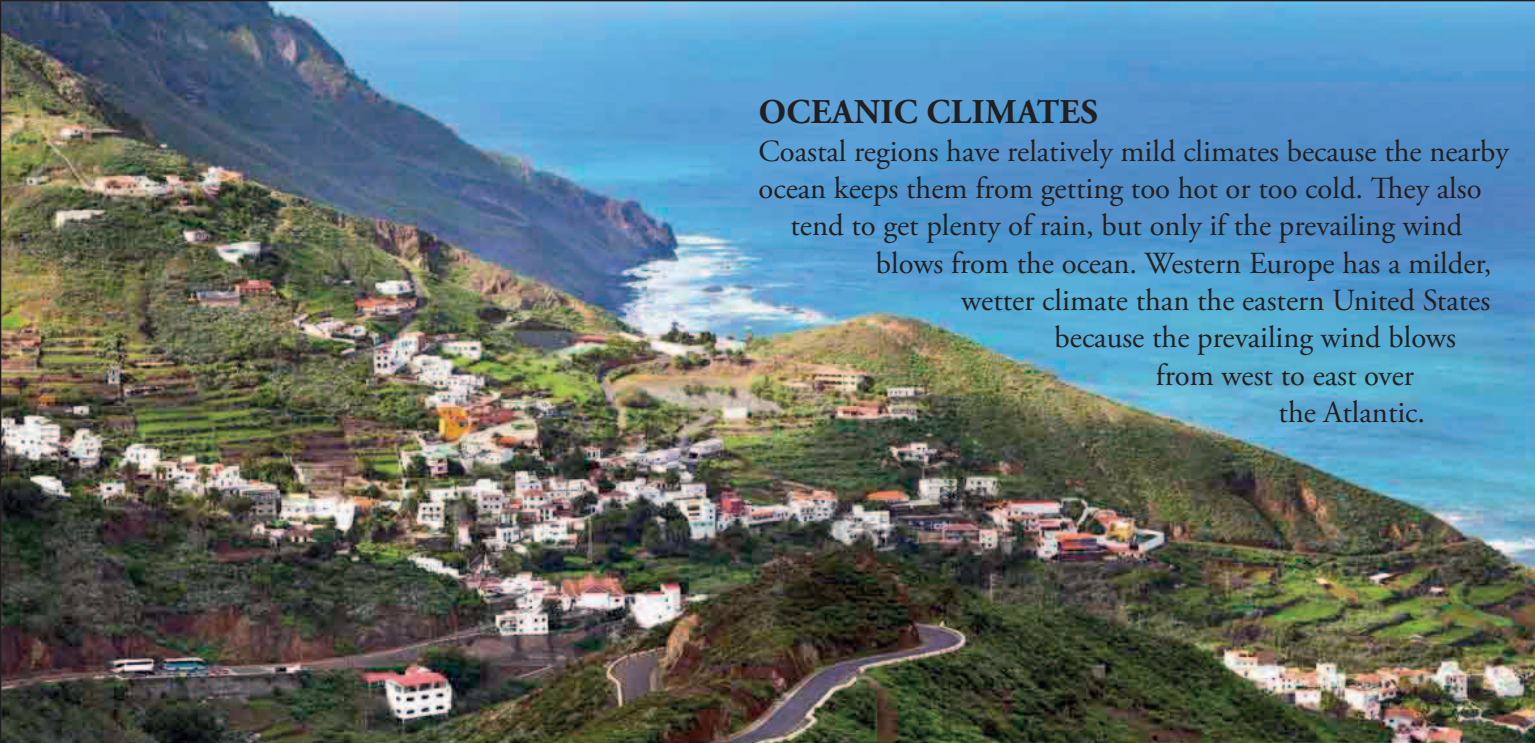




OCEANIC CLIMATES

Coastal regions have relatively mild climates because the nearby ocean keeps them from getting too hot or too cold. They also tend to get plenty of rain, but only if the prevailing wind blows from the ocean. Western Europe has a milder, wetter climate than the eastern United States because the prevailing wind blows from west to east over the Atlantic.



OCEAN CURRENTS

The effect of the ocean on climate is changed by currents that flow from other parts of the world. In the eastern Pacific, the cold Humboldt Current flowing north from Antarctica cools the Galápagos Islands, which is why penguins live there. By contrast, northern Europe is warmed by the Gulf Stream flowing up from the Gulf of Mexico.



CONTINENTAL CLIMATES

Regions in the middle of continents have extreme seasons. For example, in central Siberia, north Asia, temperatures rise to 86°F (30°C) in summer, but plunge to well below -22°F (-30°C) in winter. Verkhoyansk, Siberia (left), has seen temperatures of -90°F (-68°C), which is colder than the North Pole.

MONSOONS

Low ground temperatures in winter cool the air over the continents, so it sinks and pushes dry continental air out toward the oceans. In summer, the opposite happens, and rising warm air over the continents draws in moist oceanic air. In India, this seasonal wind change brings a winter drought and a summer deluge—a pattern known as a monsoon climate.

